

Prompts Attachment

The following document provides information and background to the prompts utilized in the “Social Interaction Experience” study. To facilitate engaging and meaningful social interactions, each participant is randomly assigned a conversation prompt at the beginning of every interaction. These prompts are designed to vary in emotional depth, topical focus, and cognitive complexity, supporting a diverse range of conversations that can elicit optimal experiences such as flow, social presence, and emotional engagement. The assignment of prompts follows a randomized structure across participants and conversation durations, ensuring that no specific prompt or topic becomes a confounding variable. The participants paired in dyads will follow the same randomization pattern to reduce waiting times throughout the experiment.

The selected conversation prompts fall into several carefully constructed categories, each representing a distinct thematic domain or cognitive-emotional challenge. The design of the prompts is grounded in the challenge–skill balance model from flow theory. The underlying assumption is that for an interaction to be optimally engaging, it must be sufficiently challenging without overwhelming the participant, and must align with the participant’s perceived social competence. Prompts that are too vague or unengaging risk under-stimulation, while those that are too personal or controversial may produce discomfort or disengagement. The structured variety in prompt categories is intended to balance emotional depth, personal relevance, and social feasibility, maximizing the likelihood of eliciting flow-like states in both human-human and human–AI interactions.

The conversational framework utilizing prompts is inspired and adapted from prior empirical designs (e.g., Kirk et al., 2024). Furthermore, Ta-Johnson et al (2022) identified common motivations and topics discussed with the social chatbot Replica, extracting the themes of intellectual, life, and works, recreation (e.g. media, hobbies, activities), mental health (e.g. emotional states, well-being, negative thoughts), connection (e.g. relationship-related topics), replica, other people, as well as current events (Ta-Johnson et al, 2022). The conversation prompts are informed and motivated by these findings and conversation topics, aiming to provide relevant, interesting and engaging conversation starters.

List of conversation prompts:

English

- **Work/Study Guided:** “Talk about a task or goal in a work or learning context and discuss strategies, obstacles, or motivations involved.”
- **Routine Guided:** “Discuss a situation from daily life, such as a routine, habit, or small decision, and explore why it matters or how it could be improved.”
- **Current Events:** “Discuss recent developments occurring globally or within your region. These may include political matters, cultural events, or notable releases in entertainment such as films or literature.”

- **Relationship Guided:** "Reflect on how people navigate friendships or social interactions—consider common challenges, unspoken norms, or moments of connection."
- **Values Guided:** "Focus your discussion on topics that are particularly meaningful to you, such as religion, family and relationships, politics or culture."
- **Controversy Guided:** "Engage in a discussion about a topic that is considered controversial within your community, culture, or country."

German Translation

- **Arbeits-/Lernkontext:** „Sprich über eine Aufgabe oder ein Ziel im Arbeits- oder Lernkontext und bespreche Strategien, Hindernisse oder Motivationen, die dabei eine Rolle spielen.“
 - **Routinen und Alltag:** „Beschreibe eine Situation aus dem Alltag, z. B. eine Gewohnheit, Routine oder kleine Entscheidung, und untersuche, warum sie wichtig ist oder wie sie verbessert werden könnte.“
 - **Aktuelle Ereignisse:** „Sprich über aktuelle Entwicklungen weltweit oder in deiner Region. Dazu können politische Themen, kulturelle Ereignisse oder bedeutende Neuerscheinungen in Film oder Literatur gehören.“
 - **Zwischenmenschliche Beziehungen:** „Reflektiere darüber, wie Menschen Freundschaften oder soziale Interaktionen gestalten – betrachte dabei häufige Herausforderungen, unausgesprochene Regeln oder verbindende Momente.“
 - **Werteorientierte Diskussion:** „Fokussiere deine Diskussion auf Themen, die dir besonders wichtig sind, z. B. Religion, Familie und Beziehungen, Politik oder Kultur.“
 - **Kontroverse Themen:** „Führe eine Diskussion über ein Thema, das in deiner Gemeinschaft, Kultur oder deinem Land als kontrovers gilt.“
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